Hawaii's Message For The World

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through the ups and downs. The delightful thing for me was seeing all of the people from every walk of life who showed up, had something to say and wanted to be part of the project.

"I'm proud of her. Everybody says they want to write a book. I've been working on a book for 40 years and it's not close to being done. Robin actually saw this one through to the finish."

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Perhaps it is because she was raised by her grandmother that Rohr has always sought the company of elders.

"One of my teachers, who I met just weeks after I got here, was Nana Veary (Emma's mother). I went on many retreats with her and studied with her. She was joy and graciousness personified."

In Nana Veary's chapter *Aloha* she recalls her grandmother inviting a stranger into her home and feeding him, later explaining that she "was not feeding the man, I was feeding the spirit of God within him."

Rohr also counts among her elder mentors the Rev. Abraham Akaka, artist John Young and historian Beatrice Krauss.

A decade ago, she and Linda Ching produced a book called *Power Stones: Letters to a Goddess*. "During that time I realized so many of the kupuna were passing on," Rohr says. "It seemed like really a wise thing to document some of their stories."

Six years ago, she and two girlfriends went to a marketing meeting in L.A. and pitched *Chicken Soup* creators Mark Victor Hansen and Jack Canfield on a Hawaii book to add to their popular series.

"They liked it, but said to beware, it's a long, long journey," Rohr recalls. "They said you have to jump through many hoops to produce this kind of book, and it might never see a printing press. And Jack Canfield said something really interesting: 'Choose your journeys well, because there's so much we're not in control of, so if the journey is interesting then it was worthwhile in and of itself.

"They also said this book should be filled with messages for the 21st century from the wisdom of Hawaii — and clearly it's the wisdom of the kupuna. More than anything these are stories of what unites us as human beings. We all, worldwide, have a love affair with family. And people want to make their individual and community dreams come true. People want to live lives of good will with integrity."

Rohr's two girlfriends would drop out of the project, but along the way Sharon Linnea signed on.

"She was involved with other *Chicken Soup* books in terms of editing, and wrote an award-winning book on Princess Kaiulani. And even though she lives in New York, her love of Hawaii runs so deep. We worked together for four years — it was very heroic of her to partner with me long distance. She made me realize there are so many people who don't live in Hawaii but who are deeply touched by these islands, and there's a haunting refrain that runs through their lives called Hawaii."

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So what exactly is a *Chicken Soup* story? Says Rohr: "Is it true? Does it touch people? Does it motivate them? Does it make you laugh or cry or give you chickenskin? Does it have a theme, an important one, about making a difference or of someone being kind or courageous?

"We want you to come away after a short read with more gas in your tank for having read that story. You invest five minutes in one of these stories and there's something incredible to chew on. There's something to reflect on while you're being entertained. How cool is that?"

Chicken Soup from the Soul of Hawaii is filled with such stories — 90 of them, ranging from two to five pages. Authors run the gamut from international celebrities (Bo Derek, Clint and Dina Eastwood, John Travolta and Kelly Preston, Jason Scott Lee, Regis Philbin) to local celebrities (June Jones, Danny Kaleikini, Larry Price, Don Ho, Fred Hemmings, Sid Fernandez) to Hawaiian cultural icons (Nalani Olds, John Lake, Kanalu Young, Makia Malo, Robert Cazimero) to students from both public and private schools.

For those prone to misting up, when you sit down with a copy of *Chicken Soup from the Soul of Hawaii* bring a box of Kleenex. The moist moments come often, and from some rather unexpected folks. Bo Derek, for instance.

"She was coming to Hawaii after the death of her husband of 25 years, a real relationship, and she was heartbroken," Rohr says. "Steve Winn called my husband, said Bo would like to stay at Waikoloa and asked if he could take care of her. I'd just come in from the Mainland, Tom said he was off to the Big Island to meet and greet somebody. And I said I'm so exhausted, would you mind if I didn't go with you. And he said, whatever you like. I said, by the way, who is it? He said Bo Derek. I said, 'Get in the car, I'll be ready in five minutes, you're not going without me.'

"She turned out to be an adorable friend. We've been on many adventures together. We've ridden wild horses in Portugal, made trips to South America because we both sit on the stewardship board for the Galapagos Islands. I broke my shoulder rollerblading with her last year."

Derek's story *The World of the Manta Rays* is about a healing experience on the Big Island during that first trip.

MidWeek columnist Larry Price contributes two chapters.

"Larry wrote one chapter that made me cry," Rohr says. "So I asked him if he could write a story that made me laugh. And he did!"

"Robin is so enthusiastic, I don't think anybody has ever said no to this wahine since the day she was born," he says. "I couldn't."

Price's story *The Benchwarmer* will surprise readers who can't imagine the former pro football player and UH football coach as a skinny little wannabe. His *Just Dropping By* tells a never-before-told piece of Beatles history, and a funny one at that.

June Jones, the current UH coach, contributes *A Reason To Play*. Asked how it feels to be an author, Coach Jones says "No, not me." In fact, his chapter is adapted from a speech Rohr heard him give at a business lunch. "When I saw people wiping tears from their eyes, I knew I wanted this story," she says.

"Football," the coach says, "is more about motivating people than X's and O's. If you can't get your people to do what you need them to do, you will not be successful." The war in Iraq, he adds, reminds him of that truth. "Unless you put other people first, do things for others instead of yourself and put team success ahead of personal gain, you'll never go very far."

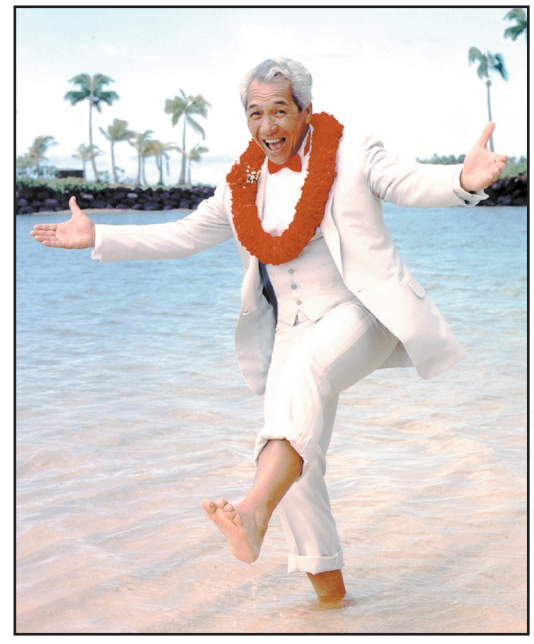

Photo courtesy Danny Kaleikini

Danny Kaleikini writes of never giving up

Nalani Olds' *The Royal Hawaiian Band* (as told to Kamehameha Schools students Stephanie Soares and A'ala Lyman) inspires smiles, tears and chickenskin. It is one of two stories she contributed.

"Nalani brought forth the Queen Liliuokalani songbook, published after 12 years of focus, and was asked to speak at libraries," Rohr says. "I so admired her and went to hear her speak, and we got to be friends."

"When I first met Robin, it was like meeting a long-lost sister," Olds says. "I come from a tradition of storytellers — my grandmother told stories punctuated with music — but even so I was blown away that they chose my stories."

Her second story, *Roots and Wings*, is based on her volunteer work in prisons using Hawaiian history and culture to "show who we are and where we come from, which you must understand before you know where you're going when you have the opportunity to leave."

Danny Kaleikini's *People Like Me* shares anecdotes from his past that will come as a surprise to many of his fans.

"The Ambassador of Aloha, what a perfect title for this man," says Rohr. "His story should encourage everyone that dreams are possible, and to never give up."

Says the ambassador: "I will believe until the day I die in the Hawaiian heart and Hawaiian values, and that we have to share that with the world. The world needs the Hawaiian heart, because it relates to everybody. That's the thing about Robin. She's a haole from California, but she gets it, she feels the mana."

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In the end, says Rohr, *Chicken Soup from the Soul of Hawaii* is about changing the way we look at the world around us.

"So much of our happiness is based on how we see the world," she says. "It's about outlook and attitude."

The outlook of her book is decidedly upbeat and positive, with hope for the future built on the wisdom and experience of the elders.

"You know how they say an optimist sees a glass that is filled halfway as being half full and a pessimist sees it as half empty? John DeFries says there is even another way to see it. As our kupuna see it, the glass is always full. He says there's water, there's air — *ha* is the breath, *wai* is water, and *i* is spirit. So in Hawaii, whether there's water in the glass or not, it's always completely filled because the spirit permeates everything."

It must be true, because I have to admit that one of my favorite stories in *Chicken Soup from the Soul of Hawaii* is written by Rod Ohira, who is on the other side of the battlefield from *MidWeek* in Honolulu's newspaper war. His *The Night God Came To Dinner* is about a remarkable meeting of American and German soldiers in World War II.

And it makes you wonder …

Photo courtesy Robin Rohr

Robin Rohr and Bo Derek, partners in adventure

Upcoming book signings with "Chicken Soup from the Soul of Hawaii" celebrity authors:

April 18 — Waldenbooks Ala Moana, 2-3 p.m.

April 19 — Barnes & Noble Kahala, 1 p.m.

April 26 — Borders Ward, 12-1 p.m.

April 27 — Borders Waikele, 12-1 p.m.

May 3 — Waldenbooks Windward Mall, 2-3 p.m.

May 10 — Bookends Kailua, 12-1 p.m.

May 10 — Waldenbooks Pearlridge, 2-3 p.m.

May 10 — Native Books and Beautiful Things Ward Warehouse, 2-3 p.m.

May 11 — Waldenbooks Ala Moana, 2-3 p.m.